

Chapter 1

Introduction: A World in Transition



To paraphrase a common theme often repeated in the media today, we live in a world of unprecedented change, the likes of which have not been seen in nearly a century. These changes are coming to a nearly century old system that can trace its origins to the Treaty of Westphalia, which laid the foundation for state sovereignty and ultimately the modern international system. That eventually took its current form in the mid-twentieth century following two world wars and the establishment of international institutions such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization and the Bretton Woods system.

Since this system was established, a general consensus has formed that major themes such as globalization and multilateralism are central to modern global governance and should be the ultimate aspiration of the global community. The prosperity that the world has experienced thanks to the stability of the “Pax Americana” following World War II also contributed to the later rise of developing countries in the Global South that began to cast off the yoke of colonial control and to assert their own rights and visions of a more egalitarian and multilateral world.

This is perhaps most true of China, most of which had been closed off to the world after the Chinese Communist Party founded the People’s Republic in 1949. Containment by Western powers due to ideological differences and domestic turmoil stemming from different visions of what form the new republic would take added to the gap that formed between what had been at one time one of the core members of the international community and much of the rest of the world.

But China would not be isolated for long. The decision of China to integrate back into the international system following Nixon’s landmark visit in 1972 and the incredible changes that came to China after implementing its policy of reform and opening up made it possible for China to take full advantage of the opportunity presented at the height of a wave of globalization that had generally made the world a more prosperous, more peaceful and more stable place than any other time in human history.

After the return of the People's Republic to global institutions like the United Nations, made possible in part by a wave of support from recently independent African and Asian countries, as well as its later entry into the World Trade Organization, China was able to build a massive trade network in the 80 s, 90 s and early 2000s, which created a momentum of global change that was nearly imperceptible, but at the same time unstoppable.

China's unique economic and political systems made its reintegration into the global system complex and fraught with issues, stemming from its system of state-owned enterprises that made up nearly its entire economy in the late-1970s, to its strong state apparatus that was, and remains, very different from many liberal democracies in the West both ideologically and structurally. However, the phrase "to link with the world",¹ common throughout much of the heady period of its reintegration, was reflected in how China worked on practical solutions to these issues and was able to successfully grow into what today is the world's second largest economy and a country that is perhaps as politically consequential as the United States in terms of major global issues.

The End of History or a New Beginning?

The fall of the Soviet Union and perceived "victory" of Western liberalism and democracy over Soviet communist authoritarianism was famously encapsulated in Francis Fukuyama's 1992 book *The End of History and the Last Man* that expanded on Fukuyama's idea that humanity has reached "not just ... the passing of a particular period of post-war history, but the end of history as such: That is, the endpoint of mankind's ideological evolution and the universalization of Western liberal democracy as the final form of human government."²

Fukuyama may have come to this conclusion a bit too early and did not take into account the resolve of China to follow its own path, which, while accepting many of the conditions of the global system already in place, has failed to fulfill the wishes of Western liberal democracies and transition to a liberal democratic system. If China had not become such an economic powerhouse or as influential of a country, perhaps its political system could be overlooked, but the apparent success of China's efficient, clean and pragmatic administrative style of government has made it a real alternative that developing countries can look to for inspiration to the generally accepted model of Western liberal democracy-based mainly on the system used in the United States.

The addition of a series of economic and social shocks in the early twenty-first century, as well as massive social change, have begun to challenge the prosperity and confidence of Western liberal democracies, contributing to the view that history has, in fact, not ended, and that alternative systems do exist and are flourishing.

¹ A translation of the Chinese *yu guoji jiegui* .

² Francis Fukuyama, "The End Of History?", *The National Interest*, No. 16 (Summer 1989), pp. 3–18.

China is perhaps the most salient example of this phenomenon. Something that has been reinforced by China's increased confidence in its own positions, policies, and practices. For China, this has resulted in not so much as a divergence from, but less of a pressing need to "link with the world" as China has established many of those key links it lacked in the early stages of its process of opening up.

A Turning Point in the Balance of Global Power

The fall of the Soviet Union resulted in what some viewed as a unipolar world, in which the United States was the only dominant power. However, as the twenty-first century dawned and countries of the Global South continued to develop economically and politically, led by an increasingly influential China, the balance of global power began to shift from West to East.

This shift was not led by China alone, but also by organizations such as BRICS and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), as well as many other institutions and organizations like the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation and the Paris Peace Forum that were working to create a more multilateral and diverse ecosystem of global governance. It was the increased economic, political, and social influence of a greater number of nations that shifted this balance of power away from a traditionally Eurocentric or US-centric model.

As we entered a new century and a new millennium, this became increasingly pronounced and unfortunately resulted in increased friction, or, at the very least, increased apprehension on the part of incumbent global powers like the United States and Western Europe. While this was not enough to shake the confidence of the established powers, a series of financial crises, a global pandemic and seemingly intractable and potentially expansive conflicts have brought the core issues of this shift to a head.

China's Role in this Transition

As President and Founder of the Center for China and Globalization, my focus is on how China fits into this new and changing world. Our research advises both decision makers in government within China as well as a wider range of scholars, think tanks, foreign governments and individuals around the world, providing a deeper view into how China views itself in the wider context of global affairs while ensuring that China's voice is represented fairly and objectively.

China's situation is unique in the world. Due to its massive size and complex geographical and demographic factors, China is still in many ways a developing country. But recent decades have seen developments in infrastructure and technology, which are not only integrated into everyday life in China, and are also light years ahead of developed countries.

Its ability to push forward policies and projects at the “speed of China” shocks many visitors. The country’s high-speed rail network, which is by far the longest in the world, reached 45,000 km (28,000 mi) in total length by end of 2023 with plans to reach 70,000 km (43,000 mi) in 2035.³ Meanwhile, its highways continue to grow, improving transportation links throughout the country, especially in much of its more geographically challenging mountainous regions. China’s expressway network reached 184,000 kilometres (114,000 mi) as of the end of 2023.⁴

Urban development has also seen great strides, with a policy of urbanization that has created some of the most populous cities in the world. While real estate markets may be reaching saturation and a turning point of their own, Chinese cities continue to become increasingly livable as quality of life continues to improve. As of December 2024, 47 cities in China had urban rail systems with 310 lines in operation, including 10 of the busiest metro systems in the world. This, combined with an increasingly cashless society, ubiquitous delivery services, all accessible online, means that urban life in China has reached a level of convenience and technological integration that is rarely seen in other places in the world.

At the same time as China has been making all of these advances domestically, it has been leveraging its strengths and advantages to expand abroad. Naturally, infrastructure and transportation has been one of the areas China has contributed most outside of its borders, especially through the Belt and Road Initiative and other bilateral agreements with mostly developing countries.

This, however, is also an area where China has received criticism, whether it be port projects in Sri Lanka, railways in Laos, or a range of development projects in African countries. From China’s perspective, it is providing the foundations upon which these developing countries can truly achieve the next stage of their development, but accusations of debt-trap diplomacy, exclusionary policies in favor of Chinese companies and other issues, have plagued China’s efforts.

Regardless of the hurdles that remain in China’s rise and integration into global systems, its essential role in a transition to a new form of global governance and modes of interaction is undeniable. But how that role is defined remains in question by many in the world. China’s fundamental position on many global issues and its efforts in cooperation is based on principles of mutual respect, mutual benefit, non-interference in internal affairs, and its overarching goal of a shared community for mankind. Time and again, China has emphasized cooperation in trade, culture and education as basic themes in its global interactions, which stands in stark contrast to many established powers that continue to emphasize exclusive security pacts that often work to limit China’s rise and its influence on global governance.

³ Frank Chen, “China sets railway building spree in high-speed motion,” *Asia Times*, August 24, 2020.

⁴ “China dominates list of the world’s top 10 longest metro networks,” *Railway Gazette International*, June 21, 2022. Retrieved July 2, 2022.

The Center for China and Globalization (CCG) and Our Work

2008 was a year remembered for many things. The world faced possibly the most violent financial upheaval in nearly a century and came to a historical turning point with seven of the world's major central banks joining forces to save financial markets and G20 leaders holding their first summit in Washington, D.C.

For China, it marked the 30th anniversary of China's reform and opening up, which brought the country back in line with the ongoing trend of globalization, as well as the 2008 Summer Olympics that were held in Beijing, championing the call for a spirit of "One World, One Dream".

For me, it was also a very personal year.

2008 was the year that I founded the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), which was the first think tank in China with a central focus on globalization, a topic that domestically had been very sensitive and even holding negative connotations.

My experiences as a "sent down youth" during the Cultural Revolution, being part of the first group to be able to attend the reinstated university entrance examinations *gaokao* and to fulfill my dream to travel the world, learning and experiencing what I had previously only heard about on my transistor radio, are in large part the reason why I established this think tank—to promote the benefits of globalization and ensure that it continues to benefit generations to come.

Similar to other countries, think tanks in China take many forms, including governmental, university-affiliated, and non-governmental think tanks. From the very beginning, CCG has been a completely non-governmental think tank, maintaining an independent, yet decidedly Chinese perspective on a number of global issues related to globalization.

Regardless of their model or affiliations, the primary goal of any China-based think tank is the overall development and betterment of the country, and ensuring that China's message and story is conveyed faithfully and fairly. This has been a personal mission of mine since CCG was founded. China officially defines non-governmental think tanks as non-profit research and consulting organizations operated by domestic non-governmental individuals or entities that focus on strategic issues and public policies, in service to the country in decision making and policy development. This is exactly what I founded CCG to do and I am proud to say that CCG is currently considered China's top non-governmental think tank and possibly one of China's most visible and active think tanks on a global level.

Our mission of promoting a "global vision for China and Chinese wisdom for the world" is an attempt to bridge the gap between East and West, taking the best attributes of both for the benefit of all. However, it has not always been easy, and CCG has often been a target of criticism both within China and from the international community. Despite these criticisms, we remain dedicated to our mission and have faith that we are making a positive impact on the global dialogue and influencing the narrative on China in a constructive and meaningful way.

Spreading the Word

CCG has dedicated itself to examining the significance of globalization for China and the world as a whole in terms of economic and trade policy, global governance and countless other areas. One of the ways we do this is by publishing our research and other materials through some of the most respected publishing houses in China and around the world. These include the People's Publishing House, China Social Sciences Press, CITIC Press, Springer, Edward Elgar and Palgrave Macmillan. Our Publishing Center has produced more than 100 books in Chinese and English on topics from China's development model to globalization over the past decade with three English-language series: "China and Globalization", "The Chinese Enterprise Globalization" and "International Talent Development in China".

These books have received broad praise and in 2022, *Consensus or Conflict?: China and Globalization in the twenty-first Century*, the first volume of the "China and Globalization" series was awarded the New Development Award by Springer Nature. Other achievements include cooperation with world-famous scholars like Professor Graham Allison, resulting in *Escaping Thucydides's Trap: Dialogue with Graham Allison on China-US Relations* as well as the "father of soft power", Professor Joseph Nye Jr., for whom we compiled a collection of op-eds titled *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition: Shifting Sands in the Balance of Power between the United States and China*. Later, Professor Nye also worked with us to translate his biography *A Life in the American Century* into Chinese and publish it in China.

Keeping the Conversation Going

I have long been a firm believer in the power of dialogue to solve world problems, finding that no matter how great our differences, as long as we sit down and talk about them, almost anything can be resolved. This is why another key part of CCG's work is holding regular forums and seminars on globalization-related themes. With the major challenges facing globalization in recent years, it is essential that China's top non-governmental think tank leads the way in promoting the exchange of knowledge and ideas between experts on globalization, government officials responsible for policymaking, and the business sector to see how China can positively contribute to the healthy growth of the global economy and the promotion of globalization.

We've participated in thousands of events over the past 18 years, some of the more notable have included major international platforms such as the Paris Peace Forum, the Munich Security Conference, the World Economic Forum, the Athens Democracy Forum, the Bled Strategic Forum, the Trilogue Salzburg, the WTO Public Forum, the Boao Forum for Asia, the Global Solutions Summit, and many more, often holding side events to bring the focus back to China's role in the conversation. Personally, I have also been honored to speak at the UN Security Council, where I was the only

Chinese briefer, as well as the Harvard China Conference, the Oxford Union—as the first Chinese think tank representative—and the first Princeton China Forum.

However, far from being a passive participant in the global dialogue, CCG organizes a wide range of our own large-scale forums, roundtable sessions and special seminars that create a variety of platforms where experts can share views on the current state of globalization, analyze changes in the fabric of global trade and provide recommendations on how decision-makers can best meet the challenges we currently face, ultimately working to reach a consensus on how the world as a whole can come together to ensure a new era of mutually beneficial globalization. These events range from our major annual events such as the China and Globalization Forum, currently in its eleventh year, as well as the China Inbound-Outbound Forum and China Global Think Tank Innovation Forum, which has become well-known for timely and constructive discussions that include members of the diplomatic community, government representatives, members of the business sector, as well as world-renowned academics. Other regular events that keep the dialogue going include our Ambassador Roundtable series as well as our VIP Luncheons that welcome a host of outstanding academics, businesspersons and government representatives.

Another way we build bridges is by welcoming important guests from around the world to CCG's headquarters in Beijing for regular discussions. Over the past three years, I've welcomed many distinguished individuals including Justin Vaïsse, founder and Director-General of the Paris Peace Forum, Ambassador Ischinger of the Munich Security Conference, Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, and Diego Martínez Belío, State Secretary for Foreign and Global Affairs of Spain to CCG to discuss pressing global issues. In 2025, we took a big step forward by launching our Beijing Academy, which has hosted many leading thinkers including Stephen Orlins, President of the National Committee on US-China Relations, and Jeffrey Sachs, Economics Professor and Director of the Centre for Sustainable Development at Columbia University. I couldn't be prouder of the work that CCG has done over the years to keep the conversation going between China and the world.

While our global interactions through forums and publications are central to CCG's mission, CCG has also become known for its high-quality research and objective analysis of major issues. Over the years we've produced reports and recommendations on trends in global development and policy that is vital to decision making at the highest level of government in China. We have submitted nearly a thousand policy suggestions and received hundreds of responses on these reports from national-level ministries and commissions, while our research reports and other publications have been recognized as essential resources by institutions like the Brookings Institution, CSIS and other major global think tanks, major multinational companies as well as universities, including Princeton University, which just recently added a collection of CCG's English-language publications to their university library.

Driving Meaningful Change

Our “blue books” are a key source of up-to-date information for the Chinese government at all levels, and one of our more notable achievements has been a plan to promote entrepreneurship among Chinese students returning from abroad by providing them with the support they need when they come home. In addition to these, we’ve also championed efforts to improve the lives of foreigners that call China a home away from home. In order to make life easier for foreign residents in China and attract more global talents, CCG pioneered proposals to reform China’s immigration system, which eventually resulted in the creation of the National Immigration Administration in 2016, which has streamlined and improved essential services for China’s international community.

I, along with CCG co-founder and Secretary General Dr. Mabel Lu Miao, have always felt that young people represent the future and the best hope for a more peaceful and harmonious world. This is why, in 2021, CCG launched the Global Young Leaders Dialogue, a project initiated by Dr. Miao to engage young professionals from both China and beyond to encourage dialogue and ensure a truly global future for generations to come. The annual GYLD Forum, in its second year, attracts young professionals from around China and across the world to engage and discuss China related and global issues.

Facing a New Global Reality

Throughout all of our research and discussions, one thing has become clear in recent years—globalization has entered a new phase of development, which in turn has placed new demands on global governance. However, the existing system of global governance seems to be unable to cope with pressing global issues. As China’s leading non-governmental think tank, CCG is in a unique position to provide a uniquely Chinese perspective on the future of global governance, make suggestions on how governance mechanisms can be adapted to a new phase of globalization, foster discussions that are conducive to improving global governance, build international consensus, and play a positive role in ensuring a more stable world order.

I have worked my entire life to bridge the gap that exists between China and the world, working to translate Chinese wisdom into practical ideas to better the world. In my mind, the United Nations remains the only international institution with the capability to drive effective global governance. However, as we move farther into the twenty-first century, the authority and effectiveness of the United Nations has declined. It is essential that we work to reform the UN into an institution that is fit for purpose and capable of once again becoming the core of an international governance system where issues related to international governance and global multilateral cooperation can be debated and work can be done to build a global consensus.

Since being granted special consultative status by the United Nations, CCG has had increasingly frequent exchanges with organizations within the United Nations system. We have co-hosted events to commemorate the 75th anniversary of the signing of the United Nations Charter and the 50th anniversary of the lawful return of China's seat in the United Nations to the People's Republic of China. UN Resident Coordinator in China Siddharth Chatterjee and other representatives from UN systems, as well as other international institutions including the World Trade Organization (WTO), the World Bank, the OECD, the International Monetary Fund, the International Labor Organization, the Paris Peace Forum, often participate in our events. CCG cooperates extensively with them to explore views on important topics in international governance, provide alternative voices from the Chinese perspective and play an important role in agenda setting on broader international issues, while at the same time taking action with these agencies to form relevant resolutions and action plans.

In addition to cooperation with global governance institutions like the UN and WTO, we have also worked with think tanks at a global level to provide solutions for other challenges facing global governance, placing a great deal of emphasis on fostering and cultivating a truly global talent pool. In 2018, at the first Paris Peace Forum, our initiative to establish an international talent cooperation organization was successfully selected, and at the third Paris Peace Forum, the Alliance of Global Talent Organization (AGTO) was formally established. The concept we have been promoting for many years has finally gone from conception into reality and the creation of the AGTO not only fills the gap in the global governance of talent resources, it also greatly enhances China's voice and contribution to the field of global talent governance. In 2025, AGTO opened its Beijing office and held its second Global Talent Summit in Tongzhou District, in the eastern part of Beijing, welcoming ambassadors and diplomats from countries including Pakistan, Iceland, Latvia, Morocco, Portugal, and Estonia, as well as over a hundred representatives and experts from the United Nations system, international organizations, universities, multinational corporations, and talent service agencies to jointly explore new trends in global talent governance and innovative paths for cooperation.

While I may have started CCG with a dream to bridge the gap between countries and peoples, I am now just one of many researchers in our extensive network of world-renowned scholars that work in fields such as international relations, economics and trade, former officials with extensive experience at the highest levels of government and multilateral institutions, Nobel laureates, prominent journalists and authors. During COVID-19, which made face-to-face interactions nearly impossible, we kept this network connected through our CCG Global Dialogues, an online series of dialogues that enabled our members to continue discussing essential issues. So far, over 100 speakers have taken part in this program, including familiar names like Graham Allison, Joseph Nye, Kishore Mahbubani, Lawrence Summers, Hank Paulson, Pascal Lamy, Arancha González Laya, Martin Wolf, Adam Tooze, Stephen Roach, Ray Dalio, Niall Ferguson, William Kirby, Anthony Saich, Susan Thornton, Douglas Paal, Neil Bush, Ronnie Chan, C. Fred Bergsten, John Hamre, Richard Haass, Justin Vaisse, Jim O'Neill, Hakan Fidan, Gordan Grli Radman, Ravi Agrawal,

Adam Tooze and Gabriela Ramos, to name just a few. The program has drawn millions of viewers, inspiring them and myself as well to reflect on themes of globalization, global governance, multipolarization and multilateralism, China-US relations, climate change, regional conflicts, common challenges and other pressing issues that humans can address only by working together.

Our work with the UN and other institutions to explore a new future for global governance is just the next step in our work to contribute to the knowledge of and solutions to a host of the world challenges. It is my sincere hope that we continue to ensure that China's voice is heard and that a consensus can be reached between governments, global institutions, think tanks and individuals. This is the future of global governance, of CCG as an institution and for me as a researcher and driver of dialogue and communication.

A View to the Future

As I look to the future, I can't help but look back as well. 18 years have passed in the blink of an eye and I can hardly believe how far we've come. CCG has become China's largest non-governmental think tank with a seasoned team of full-time researchers and administrators located in cities across China, from our headquarters in Beijing to research institutes in Guangzhou, Qingdao, Shanghai, Shenzhen and Chengdu. In addition to this, we also have representatives located in Washington, New York, London, Frankfurt, Paris, Sydney, and Rio de Janeiro, making CCG one of China's most global think tanks.

Internationally, CCG has made many friends—creating global research partnerships with a range of influential agencies from the Heritage Foundation USA, China-United States Exchange Foundation, Asia Society, Brookings Institution, and Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS) in the United States to the European Policy Center, Centre on Regulation in Europe, Italian Institute for International Political Studies (ISPI), Global Solutions Initiative, German Council on Foreign Relations (DGAP), Middle East Council on Global Affairs and CATO Institute in other key countries around the world, to ensure timely and accurate information on global trends. Domestically, CCG is also currently a member of the Belt and Road Think Tank Cooperation Alliance, the Think Tank Alliance on US Issues and the China Talent Research Society. CCG has also been designated as a postdoctoral workstation by China's National Talent Theory Research Base.

Our hard work has been rewarded. CCG was ranked 64th out of the world's top 100 think tanks in the 2020 Global Think Tank Index issued by the University of Pennsylvania and has been on the list for four consecutive years. CCG is also the first Chinese think tank to have been granted "Special Consultative Status" by the United Nations.

More than impressive numbers and notable achievements, for me CCG is a culmination of my life lessons and experiences. From humble beginnings to incredible opportunities that enabled me to go above and beyond the dreams of many other

people, I hope that my experiences and CCG's work can inspire and guide new generations of global leaders. CCG's journey has not been an easy one and we are eternally grateful to a number of private individuals and organizations that have been instrumental in our formation and growth as China's premier non-governmental think tank.

Over the years we've been lucky to have received incredible support and great praise. Terry Miller, Director of the Center for International Trade and Economics at the Heritage Foundation and Former US Ambassador to the United Nations, said "CCG represents a new type of think tank in China and its existence opens up the possibility for more cooperation with think tanks in the United States and other countries around the world. I think it is a great step forward for international cooperation and should help us to better understand cooperation between the Chinese people and Americans." Lawrence H. Summers, former US Treasury Secretary and President Emeritus of Harvard University, personally told me that CCG has done a great deal to promote greater understanding between China and the rest of the world. A regular participant in our events, John Hamre, President and CEO of the Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), and former US Deputy Secretary of Defense, has praised CCG's work and its professionalism, while Harvard professor Graham Allison said that CCG is a valuable conduit for the sharing of ideas that are often unavailable or overlooked by the English-speaking world.

Today and for the foreseeable future, globalization remains and will continue to be central to China's development. The country's leadership continues to place great value on China's active participation in globalization, often expressing China's views on globalization and vision for a future in which China is an integral part of reinvigorating and driving a more prosperous, mutually beneficial model of globalization. It is our hope at CCG, and my personal desire, that we will be able to continue to support efforts by government, business and academia to drive a model of globalization that ensures a prosperous and peaceful future.

Core Themes of this Book

CCG's work, including dialogues and joint events at universities, think tanks and international forums, have provided me with the opportunity to think deeply about globalization and global governance. To share my perspectives and the fruits of CCG's ongoing research, I regularly submit articles to domestic and international media outlets and academic journals on a range of subjects related to China and globalization.

This book mainly features a selection of my op-ed articles published between 2022 and 2025 by a number of domestic and overseas platforms including Arab News, Beijing Review, Bled Strategic Times, Bloomberg, Carleton University, CGTN, China Daily, China Focus, China-US Focus, East Asia Forum, The Economist, The Financial Times, GD Today, Global Solutions Journal, Global Times, Horizons, The

Indian Express, Institute of Montaigne, IPS Journal, Limes, Munich Security Conference, The New York Times, Nikkei, People's Daily, South China Morning Post, Trilogue Salzburg, the Wilson Center, the World Economic Forum and Xinhua, as well as my speeches at Harvard Kennedy School's China Conference, Oxford Union, Princeton China Forum and UN Security Council.

It is precisely China's evolving role in global governance and world affairs that are at the core of this book. While we will examine this topic on both macro and micro levels, the focus will be on how to better understand and better communicate China's role in a world in transition.

The three core themes of this book are: 1. changes in global interactions, whether it be between the governments of major countries like China, the US, the EU and Russia, within various regions like Africa and Southeast Asia, or in terms of business and academic exchanges; 2. perspectives on the potential for and efforts made to achieve true multilateralism and a new global balance that ensures stability, prosperity and peace for all nations; 3. an examination of the symbiotic relationship between globalization and economics, and how they can help to ensure the aforementioned goals of achieving a multilateral and balanced form of global governance.

Spanning period of a little over three years, from 2022 through early 2025, the articles contained in the book provide a glimpse into various stages of the changes that the world has experienced recently, especially in the context of the COVID-19 pandemic and the resulting social and geopolitical issues that still plague many countries as they continue to recover. This period of time also allows for a perspective on the changes in US-China relations during the Biden administration and the transition to a second Trump presidency.

This book is divided into three parts, each part focuses on one of the three core themes contained in the book, expanding on them and providing deeper insights into each of these core ideas against the backdrop of China's role and its relationship with key global players.

Part I: Interaction and Exchange: Re-examining tenuous relations in a transitional world, begins with a close look at the contentious relationship between China and the United States, which have long been cautious partners but in a more positive light, also reluctant rivals, which has inspired the title of our opening chapter: "Reluctant Rivals I—China-US relations under Trump, practical deals or more challenges?" This chapter starts by examining bilateral relations under Donald Trump, looking at the potential challenges that a Trump presidency may pose for trade between China and the US in terms of possible tariffs and trade barriers, to the potential for improvement in US-China trade relations because of the more transactional, less ideological stance taken by this president.

In the next chapter, titled "Reluctant Rivals II—China-US relations under Biden, containment and the battle for values", which provides a stark contrast to the policies of the Trump administration. In terms of its language and communication style, the Biden administration may not have used such bellicose rhetoric, but in some areas, it may have been just as, if not more, hostile to China in actual policy. The paradox of US-China relations was especially evident in the national security policies of the two countries. During the Biden administration, while the US threw soft pitches in terms

of economic policy, it ended up playing hard ball in regional security and ideology, pushing alliances such as AUKUS and the Quad, while also trying to set an absolute standard in terms of how the world should define democracy. However, it was also at this time that Track II diplomacy and other non-governmental exchange platforms had a greater chance to positively influence the direction of US-China relations and act as a balance to the growing tension between the two countries.

Chapter Four leaves North America to examine China's relations with Europe, specifically the possibilities for deeper cooperation and the promotion of a more multilateral global environment. As China-US relations become increasingly tenuous, the European Union has the potential to act as a balancing force between these two rivals. Official visits by European leaders to China as well as the obvious cracks in traditionally close relations between Europe and the US point to potentially closer cooperation with China. Especially in the wake of President Trump's latest trade war antics, the relatively openness of many European countries to cooperation with China put the EU in a position to further balance an increasingly multilateral world as well as create a floor for US-China relations resulting a more global environment.

In the next chapter, we move beyond the state to examine how academic cooperation, student exchanges and cultural interactions can help to improve relations between the peoples of countries that might otherwise lack sufficient communication through official channels. This has been especially true of China and the United States, and while Chinese students continue to flood to the United States in pursuit of higher education programs, the number of American students coming to China to study abroad remains woefully low. Improving this situation is one of China's top priorities, but despite a strong push to drive exchanges, including Chinese President Xi Jinping's commitment to invite 50,000 American students within the next five years, increasing these numbers remains difficult.

Turning closer to home, China's regional policies have been consistent, but are often misunderstood. In our sixth chapter, we explore the sources of this misunderstanding and how China works to improve its current image and clarify its position on many regional issues. It has become increasingly clear during a number of multilateral events, that one of the most effective solutions to improving understanding of China's regional policy is face-to-face communication by individuals at all levels, from government representatives to academics and individual citizens.

In the final chapter of Part I of this book, the focus turns to topics of governance and perspectives on how our planet should be managed. From consequential global issues that require the world's immediate attention like ongoing military conflicts and the threat of climate change, to the debate over democracy versus autocracy as well as the function of global institutions and how they should properly function in today's complex world.

Part II: Geopolitics and Multilateralism: Finding a Salient Solution to Geopolitical Tension, takes a closer look at the nuanced factors inherent in modern geopolitics and the pressing need for a more multilateral approach in resolving global issues. As we have mentioned previously, a change in the global power structure due to the enhanced capabilities of an increasing number of developing countries, which

naturally want their voice to be heard, has given more strength to the push for multilateralism. However, those at the top of the existing power structure see this as a threat and this has resulted in pushback, specifically targeting China and its increased role in global affairs.

However, the benefits that China can generate through its strong economic relations with much of the world, as well as its centrist approach to many of the issues that the world faces, are manifold and China has consistently championed an approach of conciliatory discussion and cooperation over the strengthening or expansion of security alliances. In this way, China has the potential to become a voice of reason in an increasingly turbulent world.

In Chapter Eight, our focus turns to China's role as a mediator in global conflict and its ability to promote peace and cooperation on a global level. From China's efforts to broker peace in the Middle East, including the successful restoration of relations between Saudi Arabia and Iran, and peace proposals for the conflict in the Gaza Strip, to its 12-point plan to bring an end to the war between Russia and Ukraine, China often has an advantage in brokering deals due to similar historic experiences with countries involved vis-à-vis the West. In the same vein, this chapter also takes a closer look at China's relationship with the Global South and how it can serve as a bridge to foster more equitable exchanges between the developed and developing worlds.

China's role in mediating conflict is expanded further in Chapter Nine, which focuses on specific geopolitical tensions and their potential solutions. As previously mentioned, US-China tensions are a major factor impacting the direction of global affairs, but as a number of top academics have noted, this does not need to be a zero-sum game, especially in terms of soft power and areas of common interest where the US and China should be able to find common ground. Cooperation in the form of a "G3" mechanism could also leverage balancing role of the EU vis-à-vis China and the US. Once this balance is achieved, active cooperation on engaging the Global South, including Africa and other developing regions, is another area that could be explored to establish common goals and find multilateral solutions to issues facing the world. This is also relevant to the role of international organizations in managing tensions and finding multilateral solutions. Primary among these is the United Nations, which is in need of urgent reform, as I described in a recent *Foreign Policy* article, which calls for a more global vision within the Security Council through both structural and procedural reform to ensure that this most important of institutions functions efficiently and effectively. Similarly, China's own Belt and Road Initiative, which has been accused of not being multilateral enough. To this end, China is actively exploring how to make the development and administration of the BRI more inclusive and multilateral. Finally, one of the possibly most beneficial, but also uncertain, source for a solution is in technology and data, which should be leveraged as a public good and not be weaponized.

Part III: Globalization and Economics: Tweaking the Sputtering Engine of Global Growth, turns to the topic of globalization and the impacts that it has made on the world, especially in recent decades. While the terminology may be new, the key elements and factors that shape and drive globalization are ancient and can even be

traced back to interactions between East and West in ancient times via the Silk Road. This ancient trade route not only fostered early economic integration, it was also key in the sharing of technologies, ideas and culture across a network that spanned half the globe. Focusing again on China, the later maritime journeys of Zheng He to South Asia, Africa, and possibly even the Americas, further highlight the global nature of China's interaction with the world.

Naturally, with the advances in global integration that have been made in communications and transportation, globalization in today's world has taken on an entirely new paradigm. It has required the world to establish broad principles that apply to all countries in order to codify and standardize the rules by which the world operates. China has benefited greatly from the current stage of globalization, becoming the world's second largest economy and one of the most consequential countries of the twenty-first century. Therefore, it is the fundamentally symbiotic relationship between globalization and economics that we focus at the end of this book, which could potentially be the foundation upon which a new era of global peace and prosperity can be built.

Chapter Ten firmly establishes a globalization as a driver of prosperity. Whether in terms of China's considerable economic success or the increased affluence of other developing nations, the evidence is clear that closer economic, diplomatic and cultural ties create a more stable and prosperous world. However, as the world continues to change and evolve, not without a certain degree of decoupling or derisking, the transition away from a West-centric model of globalization does not mean that globalization is dead, simply that it is no longer singularly American or European. Furthermore, the fact that global trade continues to play a positive role in maintaining global stability and peace, changes in global trade do not need to be fundamentally disruptive. Attempts to ensure the continuation of beneficial global trade can be small and gradual.

In the next chapter, we return our focus to China and examine its role as a driver of global growth. In the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, China recovered quickly and despite falling short of its pre-COVID historically high growth rates, China still far outpaced nearly all other economies. From an overarching national policy that maintains an emphasis on economic growth both domestically and internationally, to policies that encourage companies to explore or expand foreign investment in China, the creation of a vibrant and welcoming trade environment continues to be China's primary goal. Furthermore, China also continues to drive economic development and partnerships abroad, including economic diversification in the Middle East where we explore how China is helping economies pivot away from oil-based economies.

The twelfth chapter focuses on potential solutions to global economic woes and challenges to globalization. Addressing issues such as the future role of the BRI, China's participation in the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP), claims of overcapacity in China's manufacturing of green technologies, as well as resolving problems in the free flow of global talent, this chapter provides a number of potential solutions and explores the benefits of China's involvement in developing those solutions. The role of the BRI as a public good, the expanded reforms that CPTPP membership would drive in China, the

positive impact that China's green tech sector can have on global climate change and China's efforts to reform and relax its visa policies for a range of visitors, including businesses, students, and tourists, are just some of the solutions or positive aspects that can contribute to the continuation of globalization and economics as positive contributors to global stability and prosperity.

The subsequent two chapters supplement this collection of op-ed articles with additional material. Chapter Thirteen is a compilation of speeches that I have given throughout the years at highly respected institutions like Harvard University, Princeton University and the Oxford Union. It has been my honor to be welcomed and accepted as an equal at these events, providing me with a platform to make sure that China's voice is heard clearly and directly. Even more importantly, it is through these kinds of in-person events and personal interactions, that friendships, can be formed between colleagues that I believe have the same ultimate goal—to make the world a better place through mutual learning and understanding. This chapter also contains two memorials to two men that were recently lost to the world and for whom I have always had immense respect. The first of these is Professor Joseph Nye Jr., who passed away earlier this year. My professional relationship and personal friendship with him are some of my most treasured experiences and I will sorely miss him. The second, Dr. Edwin J. Feulner of the Heritage Foundation, was an icon in the think tank community and despite our different positions and views, his willingness to keep the channels of communication open and active was something very unique and incredibly valuable at this difficult time in US-China relations.

The next chapter of this book comes full circle with a collection of forewords from publications by the Center for China and Globalization and a reading guide for Henry Kissinger's last work *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy*, which are meant to close out this volume by visiting broader, more general concepts for the reader. From views on the rise of the Asian Century to the history of cultural exchange between Europe and China, as well as lessons from some of the greatest thinkers of the 20th and 21st centuries, these forwards hopefully bring us back to the important, overarching themes that are so important to the conversation we are having as a global family. In this way, I hope to end this book by sharing what I hope is a common vision with you, the reader, of hope. A hope that if we work together, we can create a better, healthier and more peaceful future for our world.

The final chapter closes the book by focusing on the voice of the media and how interaction with an open-minded press is an integral part of sharing views and perspectives with the wider world. Ranging from China's relations with India to how China approaches improving relations with the developed world to the impact and importance of smaller countries in the global discussion on major issues, one of the core concepts that we have tried to push is a more inclusive and united approach to global governance that emphasizes cooperation over confrontation. The last interview echoes this as it is a look at my own personal growth experience, which began with me closed off from the world during a uniquely inward-looking period in Chinese history, to an international life that exposed me to a range of cultural and systemic environments that not only broadened my own mind, but also helped me to better appreciate the Chinese way of doing things and strengthened my conviction that

China can make a positive contribution to the world as we move forward in these challenging times.

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Part I

Interaction and Exchange: Re-examining Tenuous Relations in a Transitional World

In today's world, the uncertainty created by tenuous relations between many of the world's key stakeholders has made interaction and exchange complex and difficult. Part I of this book, "Interaction and Exchange: Re-examining tenuous relations in a transitional world", contains insights that help us take another look at how relations between the world's global and regional powers are being managed as we transition to a new era of power relations.